

DOC 3

Interview Guide & Strategic Memo

Desk Research -> Live Interviews: Execution Kit + Analysis Plan

February 8, 2026

Client-ready portfolio artifact

Design system: navy + teal, structured tables, quote callouts

Snapshot	
Purpose	Convert desk research into live research execution and decision outputs.
Core modules	Strategic memo, modular guide, screening, operating plan, analysis templates.
Interview target	8-10 practitioner interviews; 45-60 minutes each.
Outputs	Workflow maps, exception library, shadow spreadsheet specs, ranked opportunity backlog.

How to use this document
Scan the Snapshot, then jump to the headings. Quotes and tables contain the highest-signal evidence. This artifact is designed for fast executive review and deep operator follow-up.

Interview Guide & Strategic Synthesis: Desk Research -> Live Research Transition

Purpose: This document translates findings from the desk research phase (Documents 1 & 2) into actionable tools for the next research stage: live qualitative interviews with practitioners. It includes a strategic memo summarizing the most promising areas for deeper investigation, a modular interview guide, and a screening framework for participant selection.

PART 1: STRATEGIC SYNTHESIS MEMO

Where the Research Points - Summary for Product & Strategy

To: Product & Strategy Lead

From: Research Lead - Santiago Garcés

Date: February 8, 2026

Re: Desk Research Findings - Recommended Focus Areas for Live Interviews

After systematically reviewing 300+ public sources across 7 business functions, three areas emerge as the strongest candidates for deeper investigation and potential product intervention. These are ranked by a combination of:

- Frequency - how often the pain point appeared independently across sources
- Severity - how much time, money, or risk the pain point creates
- Cross-functional relevance - whether the pattern repeats across multiple roles and industries
- Automation potential - whether the underlying workflow has characteristics suitable for automation (structured, repetitive, rule-based, handoff-dependent)

RECOMMENDED FOCUS AREA 1: Cross-Departmental Handoffs and Status Tracking

Why this is the top priority:

This is the single most consistent source of operational friction across all functions researched. Every function described waiting on, chasing, or manually coordinating with other teams. The common element is that these handoffs happen through unstructured channels (email, Slack, verbal) with no workflow layer providing visibility, accountability, or status tracking.

Key characteristics of the problem:

- The requester sends a message and then has no visibility into whether the recipient has seen it, started it, or completed it
- Follow-up is manual and socially costly ("I don't want to be the annoying person who sends three reminder emails")
- There is no escalation path - if the recipient doesn't respond, the requester can only wait or escalate informally
- The same handoff patterns repeat monthly (close inputs, reconciliation data, etc.) but are re-initiated from scratch each cycle

Interview hypothesis to test:

"Operational bottlenecks are primarily caused by unstructured handoffs between teams, not by complexity within any single team's workflow."

What we need to learn in interviews:

- How do practitioners currently track requests they've sent to other teams?
- What happens when a handoff stalls? Who notices, and how?
- Have they attempted to formalize these handoffs? What worked and what didn't?

- What would "just enough structure" look like for these handoffs?

RECOMMENDED FOCUS AREA 2: Shadow Tracking Systems (The Spreadsheet Layer)

Why this matters:

Every function researched has practitioners maintaining personal or team spreadsheets that serve as their real operating system - often more trusted and more relied upon than the company's official tools. These shadow systems represent a massive signal: they reveal exactly which workflows the market's existing tools fail to support.

Key characteristics:

- The spreadsheet typically tracks a multi-step, multi-person workflow (close checklist, renewal tracker, license inventory, contract expirations)
- It was built by one person, incrementally, over months or years
- It's usually not shared real-time with leadership or other teams
- It represents significant institutional knowledge that is fragile (key-person risk) and invisible to the organization

Interview hypothesis to test:

"Practitioners' personal tracking spreadsheets are a reliable map of the most valuable workflows to automate - they reveal where official tools fail."

What we need to learn in interviews:

- Can you show me the spreadsheet(s) you maintain outside your main systems? What does each column/tab track?
- Why did you start building this? What wasn't your official tool doing?
- Who else uses or depends on this spreadsheet?
- What would happen if you stopped maintaining it tomorrow?

RECOMMENDED FOCUS AREA 3: Exception Handling and Non-Standard Cases

Why this matters:

Official processes and tools are generally designed for the happy path - standard cases that follow expected patterns. The desk research consistently found that practitioners spend disproportionate time on exceptions: the invoice that doesn't match, the order with non-standard terms, the employee who needs access to a tool that's not on the standard list. These exceptions are handled ad hoc, with no defined workflow, and the resolution knowledge lives in people's heads.

Key characteristics:

- Exceptions are predictable in aggregate (they always happen) but unpredictable in specifics (each one is slightly different)
- Resolution often requires judgment, cross-referencing, and communication with multiple parties
- There is almost never a documented playbook for exception handling
- Exceptions create downstream delays because they block the next step in a dependent workflow

Interview hypothesis to test:

"The highest-ROI automation opportunity is not automating the happy path (which is often already tolerable) but providing structure and visibility for exception handling."

What we need to learn in interviews:

- Tell me about the last time something didn't follow the normal process. What happened?
- How do you currently decide what to do when you encounter an exception?
- Is there anyone you go to for help resolving exceptions? How do you reach them?
- How often do exceptions cause delays in other processes?

PART 2: MODULAR INTERVIEW GUIDE

This guide is designed to be modular - not every question needs to be asked in every interview. Select modules based on the participant's role and the focus area most relevant to them. Target interview length: 45-60 minutes.

MODULE 0: WARM-UP AND CONTEXT (Use in every interview - 5 min)

Goal: Establish the participant's role, team size, and general operational environment.

1. Can you tell me about your current role? What does your team look like?
2. In a typical week, what takes up most of your time?
3. How would you describe the tools and systems you use daily? Are they mostly working well, or is there a lot of duct tape holding things together?

MODULE 1: WORKFLOW MAPPING (Select for any participant - 10-15 min)

Goal: Get a concrete, step-by-step description of a specific recurring workflow.

4. I'd like to understand a specific process you run regularly - maybe something that happens weekly or monthly. Can you walk me through it step by step? Start from the very beginning: what triggers the process?
5. At each step, what tool are you using?
6. Where does information come from? Who gives it to you, and how?
7. Where does your output go? Who do you hand it off to, and how?
8. Are there steps where you're waiting on someone else? What do you do while you wait?
9. How long does this process take end-to-end? How long do you think it should take?

MODULE 2: SHADOW SYSTEMS AND WORKAROUNDS (Select when participant mentions spreadsheets, personal docs, or "my own system" - 10 min)

Goal: Understand what practitioners track outside their official tools and why.

10. You mentioned [spreadsheet / personal tracker / Notion doc]. Can you tell me more about that? What does it track?
11. When did you start building it? What problem were you trying to solve?
12. Does anyone else on your team use it or depend on it?
13. What would happen if you stopped updating it tomorrow?

14. What does this spreadsheet track that your official system doesn't?
15. Have you ever tried to replace it with an official tool? What happened?

MODULE 3: HANDOFFS AND DEPENDENCIES (Select for participants who work cross-functionally - 10 min)

Goal: Understand where cross-departmental coordination creates friction.

16. In the process you described, where do you depend on someone from another team? What do you need from them?
17. How do you request that input? Email, Slack, a system, a meeting?
18. How do you know when they've completed their part?
19. What happens when they're late or when the input isn't what you expected?
20. How do you follow up? How many times do you typically need to follow up?
21. Have you ever tried to formalize this handoff - like creating a form or a shared tracker? What happened?

MODULE 4: EXCEPTION HANDLING (Select for participants in operations, finance, or process-heavy roles - 10 min)

Goal: Understand how non-standard cases are handled.

22. Tell me about the last time something didn't follow the normal process. What happened?
23. How did you figure out what to do?
24. Is there a documented playbook or decision tree for handling exceptions? Or is it more "figure it out as you go"?
25. Are there certain types of exceptions that come up repeatedly?
26. How long do exceptions typically take to resolve compared to standard cases?
27. Who's the person you go to when you're stuck on an exception? How do you reach them?

MODULE 5: TOOL LANDSCAPE AND FRAGMENTATION (Select when participant uses 3+ tools - 10 min)

Goal: Understand the participant's actual tool ecosystem and where it breaks down.

28. Let's list out every tool you touch in a typical day. Can we go through them?
29. For each tool: what do you use it for? How much of your day is spent in it?
30. Are there places where you move information from one tool to another manually? Can you give me an example?
31. If you could wave a magic wand and connect any two of these tools, which would you connect and why?
32. Is there a tool your company pays for that you've stopped using or barely use? Why?

MODULE 6: CLOSE AND ASPIRATIONS (Use in every interview - 5 min)

Goal: Capture the participant's own framing of the problem and what better would look like.

33. If you could change one thing about how this process works, what would it be?
34. What would it mean for you personally if that friction went away? What would you do with that time?
35. Is there anything I didn't ask about that you think I should understand about how your team works?

PART 3: PARTICIPANT SCREENING AND RECRUITMENT FRAMEWORK

Based on the desk research, the following participant profiles will yield the richest interview data:

Tier 1 - Highest Priority

Role	Why	Target Company Size	Key Topics
Controller / Senior Accountant	Owns the month-end close workflow end-to-end; highest exposure to handoff friction and shadow systems	50-300 employees	Close process, checklist, reconciliation, cross-dept dependencies
IT Operations Manager / Senior Sysadmin	Owns onboarding/offboarding	100-500 employees	Onboarding/offboarding, access management, shadow

	workflow; cross-functional by nature; acute pain around employee lifecycle		scripts, license management
Customer Success Manager (mid-market B2B SaaS)	Daily tool fragmentation; rich shadow systems; clear articulation of pain	N/A (role-specific)	Context fragmentation, health scores, renewal prep, handoff from sales

Tier 2 - High Priority

Role	Why	Target Company Size	Key Topics
Sales Operations Manager / Analyst	Owns quote-to-close workflow; CRM data quality; commission calculation	100-500 employees	CRM hygiene, commission calculation, quote-to-contract, forecasting
HR Operations / People Ops Manager	Owns employee lifecycle processes; cross-functional coordination	100-500 employees	Onboarding, offboarding, status changes, benefits enrollment
Procurement Manager / Buyer	Owns purchasing workflow; PO management; vendor coordination	50-500 employees	PO workflow, approval chains, vendor management, exception handling

Tier 3 - Supplementary

Role	Why	Target Company Size	Key Topics
Legal Operations Manager	Contract lifecycle; review queue management	200+ employees	Contract tracking, review prioritization, renewal tracking
Operations Manager (manufacturing, distribution, logistics)	ERP exception handling; inventory reconciliation	50-300 employees	ERP workarounds, exception handling, shadow tracking

Screening Questions for Recruitment

36. What is your current role and how long have you been in it? (Filter for 1+ year tenure)
37. How many people are on your team? (Filter for 2-20)
38. Do you use any spreadsheets or personal tracking systems outside your company's main tools to manage your work? (Filter for yes)
39. Is there a recurring process in your role that you'd describe as "more painful than it should be"? (Filter for specific, articulate answers)

PART 4: RESEARCH PHASE INTEGRATION MAP

This diagram shows how the three research documents work together:

DOCUMENT 1 (Deep Dive Report)	DOCUMENT 2 (Pain Point Database)	DOCUMENT 3 (Interview Guide & Strategy)
[Deep qualitative research] -> [Structured cross-functional pattern database] -> [Strategic memo + hypotheses + interview guide + screening]		

These three documents together demonstrate the full arc of what the client is hiring for: finding signal in noise -> organizing it into patterns -> translating it into strategic action.

PART 5: LIVE RESEARCH OPERATING PLAN (How We Run Interviews)

Interview Operating Principles

- Bias toward concrete workflows over opinions. Always anchor on a recent example.
- Drive toward artifacts: screenshots (anonymized), spreadsheets, checklists, ticket examples, forms.
- Treat the spreadsheet as a product requirements document.
- Capture handoffs as states: Requested -> Acknowledged -> In progress -> Blocked -> Completed.

Logistics and Setup

Item	Standard
Interview length	50 minutes (45 min interview + 5 min wrap)
Format	Video call + optional screen share
Recording	Audio recording when permitted + written notes always
Note-taking	One interviewer + one note-taker (or interviewer uses template)
Anonymization	Remove company and personal identifiers in all notes
Consent	30-second script at start (below)

Incentive	Gift card or donation equivalent (client-dependent)
-----------	---

30-Second Consent Script (Reusable)

"Thanks for making time. This is a research interview about how work gets done day to day. We will not share your name or company in any outputs. With your permission, I'd like to record audio so I can focus on the conversation. If you'd prefer not to be recorded, that's totally fine - I will only take notes. Are you OK with audio recording?"

Post-Interview Debrief (10 Minutes, Internal)

Immediately after each interview, capture:

- Top 3 takeaways (in the participant's words)
- The single most painful step (and why)
- The spreadsheet or shadow system present (yes/no, what it tracks)
- The most common exception type mentioned
- Biggest adoption blocker for any new tool (pricing, trust, change management, integrations)

PART 6: ANALYSIS AND SYNTHESIS PLAN (How We Convert Interviews Into Decisions)

Coding Framework (Fast and Consistent)

Use the Friction Taxonomy from Document 2 as primary codes, plus emergent codes when needed.

Code Type	Examples	Output
Primary friction code	MH, TF, SS, AB, EH, KC, FT, TS, DE	Tag each pain point
Workflow state	Trigger, Step, Handoff, Wait, Exception, Output	Map end-to-end
Impact tag	Time, Risk, Cash, Customer impact, Compliance	ROI logic
Evidence strength	Direct example, artifact shown, repeated pattern	Prioritization weight
Adoption constraint	Budget, complexity, trust, switching cost, integrations	Go-to-market risk

Severity Scoring (Interview-Level)

Score each recurring pain point on 1-5 across four dimensions. Use this to build a ranked opportunity backlog.

Dimension	1	3	5
Time cost	<30 min/month	4-8 hrs/month	20+ hrs/month
Risk	Minor annoyance	Frequent rework	Material financial/security/compliance risk
Predictability	Rare	Monthly	Weekly/daily
Automatable structure	Highly ad hoc	Mixed	Structured + rule-based + repeatable

Synthesis Outputs (Client-Ready Deliverables)

- Workflow maps: 2-3 target workflows with annotated friction points
- Shadow system inventory: what exists, why it exists, what columns represent, who depends on it
- Handoff map: cross-team requests and the "status visibility gap"
- Exception library: top exception categories and current resolution methods
- Opportunity backlog: ranked list with ROI rationale and adoption constraints
- MVP hypotheses: 3-5 thin-slice product wedges that replace the spreadsheet layer first

Decision Gates (Avoid False Certainty)

- After 3 interviews: update guide based on what actually produces signal
- After 6 interviews: confirm top 2-3 patterns across roles
- After 8-10 interviews: finalize opportunity ranking and wedge hypotheses
- Stop rule: stop recruiting a profile when new interviews produce no new pain points (pattern saturation)

PART 7: TEMPLATES (Copy-Paste)

Interview Note Template (One Page)

Field	Notes
Participant role + tenure	
Company size + industry	
Tools named (actual stack)	
Workflow discussed	
Trigger event	
Steps (numbered)	
Handoffs (to/from, channel)	
Shadow system present	
Exceptions (top 3)	
Time spent (current vs ideal)	
Failure modes / risk	
Quotes (verbatim)	
Any artifact shown	

Adoption blockers	
Potential wedge	

Shadow Spreadsheet Spec Template

Column / Tab	What it tracks	Why it's needed	Who uses it	Replacement requirements

Exception Log Template

Exception type	Example	Current resolution	Time to resolve	Who gets pulled in	Downstream impact

PART 8: RECRUITING ASSETS (Outbound Copy)**Short LinkedIn / Email Outreach**

Subject: Quick research interview on finance ops workflows (50 minutes)

Hi [Name] - I am conducting research on how month-end close and cross-team handoffs actually work in practice at small and mid-market companies. I am looking for practitioners (controllers, senior accountants, finance ops) who can walk through a real workflow and the spreadsheets/workarounds behind it.

If you are open to a 50-minute call next week, I will keep it strictly practical (no sales). We will anonymize everything in outputs. Happy to share a short summary of insights afterward.

Thanks,

Santiago

Screenener Link Copy (If Using a Form)

"We are speaking with operators who run recurring workflows and maintain any spreadsheets or trackers outside official systems. Interviews focus on step-by-step process mapping, handoffs, exceptions, and the shadow spreadsheet layer."